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Investigations into Ancient Egyptian Concepts of the Dead Body

A Case Study on the Lexemes *ḫ3.t* ('corpse') and *sʿḥ* ('mummy')

Until today, the various ancient Egyptian methods of mummification in terms of the external shape of a body, its modification and optimization, are the topic of many scientific essays in Egyptology. However, the question of which ancient Egyptian lexemes can refer to a 'dead body' is often neglected. So far, there has been no detailed examination of how a dead body could be thought of, described and explicated in ancient Egyptian texts. Since such a comprehensive philological study is a desideratum in Egyptology, I examine ancient Egyptian textual sources for statements on the dead body in my research project.[1] The aim is furthermore to uncover the concepts of the corpse from an emic perspective. In order to achieve this, methods were chosen that allow a direct and unbiased work with ancient Egyptian texts. These are, on the one hand, the identification of significant collocations (historical semantics) and, on the other, the study of classifiers (prototype theory).[2] While part of the research project is dedicated to overarching perceptions on the corpse, there will also be a lexicography of ancient Egyptian lexemes that may carry the meaning 'dead body'.

1. MODERN PERCEPTIONS ON THE CORPSE

In general, a distinction can be made between an untreated and preserved dead body. While an untreated corpse shows various stages of decay over time, the decomposition process of a treated body has been stopped (naturally or artificially) at a certain point. Thus, dead bodies can be divided into different categories, which can also be found in linguistic usage. In English, the word 'corpse' initially referred to the human and animal body, whether living or dead. Nowadays, only the mortal shells of humans and animal cadavers are called 'corpses'. However, the term 'corpse' mainly refers to the dead body of a human and is thus close to the German word '*Leichnam*' which exclusively

1. The title of my dissertation project is 'The Dead Body: Studies on Concepts of the Corpse in Ancient Egypt', which is founded by the Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft (DFG, German Research Foundation)—215342465 / GRK 1876.
2. For these already quite established methods see, for example, Goldwasser 2002; Goldwasser, Grinevald 2012, pp. 55–112; Pommerening, Bisang 2017; Fritz 2005; and Allan 2012. An introduction of these methods and their modification will be given in the publication of my research project.

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describes the mortal shell of a human being.[3] Currently, a corpse seems to be usually associated with putrefaction, as long as no appropriate countermeasures are taken or natural conditions stop the decay process.[4] On the other hand, a corpse that has been preserved in a natural or artificial way is generally referred to as 'mummy'.[5] It should be examined whether a corresponding typification of dead bodies can also be found in ancient Egyptian textual sources. Therefore, the lexemes *ḫꜣ.t* and *sʿḥ* are examined in the following, which are translated as 'corpse' and 'mummy' and thus imply that they refer to two different types of dead bodies.[6]

2. CASE STUDY: *Ḫꜣ.T* AND *SʿḤ* – TWO LEXEMES USED SYNONYMOUSLY?

According to the *Wörterbuch der aegyptischen Sprache*, the lexeme *ḫꜣ.t* is translated as 'corpse' while the word *sʿḥ* describes a 'mummy' or 'figure'.[7] Despite these different translations, both lexemes can sometimes refer to the same dead body, as shown, for example, in a passage from the TB 89 spell:[8]

rʿ n rḏi.t ḥtp bꜣ ḫꜣ.t=f	Spell for making the ba rest on his 'corpse':
[…]	[…]
mꜣn=f ḫꜣ.t=f ḥtp=f sʿḥ=f	May he see his 'corpse' and come to rest on his 'mummy'!

The spell itself has the purpose to reconnect the ba with the body of the deceased. Often, TB 89 is accompanied by a vignette showing the exact moment of the ba's return.[9] The text and the vignette thus refer to the same event. However, the body which the ba does approach is named *ḫꜣ.t* ('corpse') as well as *sʿḥ* ('mummy') in the spell. This leads to the question of whether the two lexemes *ḫꜣ.t* and *sʿḥ* should generally be regarded as synonyms from an emic point of view and therefore translated identically. To answer this, a closer look to the most specific classifiers as well as an analysis of the most significant collocations of both lexemes is needed.

3. For the meaning of corpse, see www./oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/defintion/english/corpse. For the meaning of *Leichnam*, see www.duden.de/rechtschreibung/Leichnam.
4. For an overview of various stages of decay and the natural conditions that enable the body to be preserved, see Wieczorek et al. (eds.) 2007, pp. 3–68.
5. For the meaning of mummy, see www./oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/defintion/english/mummy.
6. Within the scope of this article, of course, only part of the observations on the lexicographic study on the lexemes *ḫꜣ.t* and *sʿḥ* can be discussed. A more detailed consideration will be given in my thesis.
7. *Wb* III, 359; *Wb* IV, 51–52.
8. pLondon BM EA 10477 [1, 7]; Lapp 1997, pl. 51.
9. Taylor 2001, p. 21, fig. 8.

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2.1. CLASSIFIERS OF *ḫȝ.t* () AND *sʿḥ* () IN COMPARISON

The lexeme *ḫȝ.t* is documented since the appearance of the pyramid texts and used throughout ancient Egyptian history. However, it is not before the Middle Kingdom that a uniform spelling and classification is established. From this point on, the lexeme *ḫȝ.t* is classified with the hieroglyphs Aa2 () or Aa3 ().[10] In general, these signs seem to classify words like *wbn.w* ('wound'), *šf.wt* ('swelling'), *ḫȝ.t* ('disease') or *ḥwȝ* ('to decompose, rot'), which have rather pejorative meanings. It is also striking that Aa2 () and Aa3 () are used as classifiers for words such as *wt.j* ('embalmer') or *srwḫ* ('embalm'), which are directly related to mummification.[11] Thus, Aa2 () and Aa3 () seem mainly to classify things, people and activities that have the potential to be perceived as bad, unpleasant or dangerous, but can also be averted or dealt with (fig. 1).[12]

In the meaning as 'mummy', the lexeme *sʿḥ* is documented since the early New Kingdom and is used until the Graeco-Roman period. The lexeme is usually classified with the hieroglyph A53 (), which shows an upright figure. With regard to its shape, the sign can be compared with an anthropomorphic mummy or an inner coffin, as they are created from the Middle Kingdom period onwards. As such, the hieroglyph A53 () is already interpreted in Gardiners' signs list.[13] In this form, the body has already undergone some sort of treatment. As a classifier, the sign A53 () appears in words such as *ɔb.wt* ('appearance'), *ḫpr.w* ('transformation'), *smḫ* ('image'), *snn* ('likeness'), *ḳd* ('form') or *twt* ('statue') (fig. 2).[14] In general, these lexemes mostly refer to statues of deities as well as deceased and living persons, which are depicted in an upright position and can be perceived as an image of its owner. Furthermore, a certain degree of reverence is paid to them. This aspect also seems to be important for the conceptualization of the lexeme *sʿḥ*.

The lexemes *ḫȝ.t* and *sʿḥ* can both describe a dead body. However, from the emic perspective, they are assigned to two different categories according to their most relevant classifiers Aa2 () and A53 (). While the lexeme *ḫȝ.t* is classified as something potentially unpleasant or bad, the lexeme *sʿḥ* is associated with a specific anthropomorphic shape and furthermore with something dignified.

10. So far, it has not been conclusively clarified what these hieroglyphs could represent. Therefore, a detailed examination of Aa2 () und Aa3 () will be given in my thesis.
11. *Wb* I, 379; *Wb* III, 50, 224; *Wb* IV, 368, 455.
12. See also Pommerening's remarks on the specific choice of classifiers in medical texts, Pommerening 2016, pp. 191–194.
13. Gardiner 1927 (ed. 1994), p. 447.
14. *Wb* I, 8; *Wb* III, 265–266, 460; *Wb* IV, 141; *Wb* V, 75–77, 255–256.

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2.2. ANALYSIS OF SIGNIFICANT COLLOCATIONS FOR THE LEXEME *ḤȝT* ()

The collocation of the lexeme *ḫȝ.t* with verbs of decay is frequently documented. A particularly illustrative textual source for this is the spell TB 154:[15]

rˁ n tm rḏi.t sbi.w ḫȝ.t	Spell to prevent the *ḫȝ.t* from perishing:
[…]	[…]
sbi.ty=fy pri bȝ=f m-ḫt mt=f	He, who will pass away, whose ba goes out after he dies.
hȝi=f m-ḫt sbi=f	He descends after he has passed away.
swt pw ḫnn=f	That he is, by decaying:
ḳs.w=f tm.w ḥwȝ=sn	All his bones, they rot,
smȝ.w ḥˁ.w=f	slaughtered is his body,
sgnn.w ḳs.w	the bones are weakened,
jri.w jwf m ḏw	the flesh has become (something) bad.
snsn=f ḥwȝ=f	That he stinks is by rotting.
ḫpr=f m fnṯ.w ʿšȝ.w tm.w fnṯ.w tm.w	He turns completely into numerous maggots, completely maggots!

In this spell, the process of decomposition is described quite vividly and detailed, which is rather unusual for ancient Egyptian texts. According to the spell, the decay begins directly after the ba has left the body of the deceased.[16] For instance, it is said that the bones (*ḳs.w*) of the deceased begin to rot (*ḥwȝ*) and that the body (*ḥˁ.w*) itself is slaughtered (*smȝ*), which might refer to the fact that the limbs separate from the body during decay. The decomposition process is furthermore described as something unpleasant, since the slowly rotting flesh (*jwf*) develops a bad smell (*ḏw*, *snsn*)

15. pLondon BM EA 10477 [1, 7–9]; Lapp 1997, pl. 51–52.
16. The separation of the ba from the body of the newly deceased is first addressed here, because as long as a person lives, body and ba do not separate. But through the disappearance of the soul, the dead body is conceptualized as a lifeless shell or at least as soulless.

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and maggots (*fnṯ.w*) begin to disintegrate the corpse until it finally becomes a formless mass consisting entirely of worms. Comparing this description with the most typical stages of decay, it can be said that at least certain stages are described quite accurately, since the spell mentions the putrefaction of the flesh, bones decomposition and insect infestation.[17] From an emic perspective, however, this natural process is not desirable. This can already be inferred from the title of TB 154, which says that the purpose of the spell is, that the *ḫɔ.t* does not perish. At a later point of the spell, the deceased himself mentions that his *ḫɔ.t* will not be affected by the decay process:[18]

n ḥwɔ=j	I have not rotted!
n ḫnn=j	I have not decayed!
n jmk=j	I have not decomposed!
nn ḫpr=j m fnṯ.w	I shall not turn into maggots!
[…]	[…]
ḫɔ.t=j mn.tj	My *ḫɔ.t* is permanent!
n skỉ=s	It does not perish!
n ḥtm=s m tɔ pn ḏ.t	It will not be destroyed in this land forever!

Interestingly, this passage predominantly uses the lexemes that have already described the decay process before (*ḥwɔ*, *ḫnn*, *fnṯ.w*). However, they are now packed into negation sentences, which thus makes it clear that the natural process of decay does not affect the *ḫɔ.t*. The opposite is the case, as it is mentioned that the *ḫɔ.t* does not perish (*skỉ*) and exists for all eternity (*mn*, *ḏ.t*).

As the textual sources show, the *ḫɔ.t* is a kind of dead body which is potentially always threatened by decay, but should ideally be preserved.[19] This aspect fits the categorization of the lexeme by its classifier Aa2 (𓊮). Overall, the modern translation of *ḫɔ.t* as 'corpse' thus also corresponds to the emic perception.

17. Wieczorek et al. (eds.) 2007, pp. 3–68.
18. pLondon BM EA 10477 [17, 20–21]; Lapp 1997, pl. 51–52.
19. For this ideal state of the corpse, however, appropriate measures must be taken, for example through manual actions (embalming) or ritual activities (recitation of funerary texts).

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2.3. ANALYSIS OF SIGNIFICANT COLLOCATIONS FOR THE LEXEME *sʿḤ* ( )

Collocations of the lexeme *s'ḥ* with verbs of decay are not significantly documented. However, the textual sources often mention that specific treatments have already been carried out on the *sʿḥ*:[20]

sꜣḳ ḥʿ.w=f ḫntt sʿḥ=f ḥnʿ šms.w Ḥr.w	After his body was put back together, his *s'ḥ* passed upstream together with the entourage of Horus.

The example text given above refers to the dead body of Osiris. According to legend, the god was murdered by Seth, who afterwards dismembered his brother's corpse. However, the goddesses Isis and Nephthys collected all the body parts and put the Osiris' corpse back together. The 'putting together' (*sʿḳ*) of a corpse is in my opinion a reference to the embalming, since this action reverses the natural decay process. The once again put together (*sʿḳ*) body (*ḥʿ.w*) of Osiris is then transported in a barque on the the Nile to be buried on the west bank. It is particularly noteworthy here that the body of the God is only called *sʿḥ* after this treatment. Thus, it can be implied that the body of a deceased has to undergo a certain treatment before it can be described as *sʿḥ*. Furthermore, the into a *sʿḥ* transformed body seems to hold a certain kind of dignity, as the following text example shows:[21]

sʿḥʿ.tw sʿḥ.w=sn m-bꜣḥ Rʿ jw rmṯ=sn m nḫ.wt	Their *sʿḥ.w* are placed in front of Re, while their people are in lamentation.

As the document shows, the *sʿḥ* is illuminated one last time by the sun or sun god (*Rʿ*) before the actual burial. The aspect of the setting up (*sʿḥʿ*) of the *sʿḥ*, which is mentioned in several textual sources, should be emphasized. According to this remark, the *sʿḥ* seems to have been placed in an upright position before the burial. This circumstance can be compared with the representation of the sign A53 (), which classifies the lexeme *sʿḥ*. In addition, the source given above can be compared with many iconographic representations:

Fig. 3 shows a scene from the *Book of the Dead* of Hunefer. The transformed anthropomorphic corpse of Hunefer is shown in an upright position in front of his tomb. Two mourning women are in front of the corpse. Depiction (fig. 3) and textual source thus refer to the same event. In this position, the mouth opening ceremony could be performed on the corpse of the deceased, as it is shown in fig. 3.[22] It is known that this ritual was firstly performed on the statues of gods, kings and deceased persons. By touching the sensory organs (mouth, eyes, nose, etc.), the statue was enabled to use all bodily functions. Later, the opening of the mouth ritual was also performed on the transformed corpse. Through the ritual, the mortal shell of the deceased should be revived.[23]

20. pBrooklyn 47.218.84 [x+16,3]; Meeks 2006, pp. 35–36.
21. Hari 1985, pp. 36–40, pl. 26, 68–69.
22. 22. For further corresponding representations see Assmann 2001, pp. 140, 187.
23. Otto 1960, pp. 1–10.

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The mouth opening ritual is closely related to the *sʿḥ*, since the lexeme designates both the externally transformed corpse and correspondingly shaped statues.[24] Moreover, the classifier A53 () places the lexeme *sʿḥ* precisely in this category.

In general, the lexeme *sʿḥ* refers to a transformed body. However, since the modern meaning of 'mummy' was unknown in ancient Egypt, I would like to suggest to translate the lexeme *sʿḥ* as 'figure' or 'image' in the sense of an externally transformed (anthropomorphic) manifestation of the deceased.

While the classifiers and significant collocations of *ḫɜ.t* show that this lexeme refers to a kind of dead body potentially threatened by decomposition, the classifiers and significant collocations of the lexeme *sʿḥ* indicate that lexeme describes a dead body which can no longer decay because it has already undergone a certain stage of (an external) transformation. Both lexemes thus describe different types of dead bodies and are therefore not usually used as synonyms.[25]

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24. The corpse transformed into a *sʿḥ* is ultimately an image of the deceased. A similar view is described in Assmann 2000, pp. 99–105.

25. Other significant classifiers and collocations as well as their significance for the conception of the lexemes *ḫɜ.t* and *sʿḥ* are presented and discussed in my thesis.

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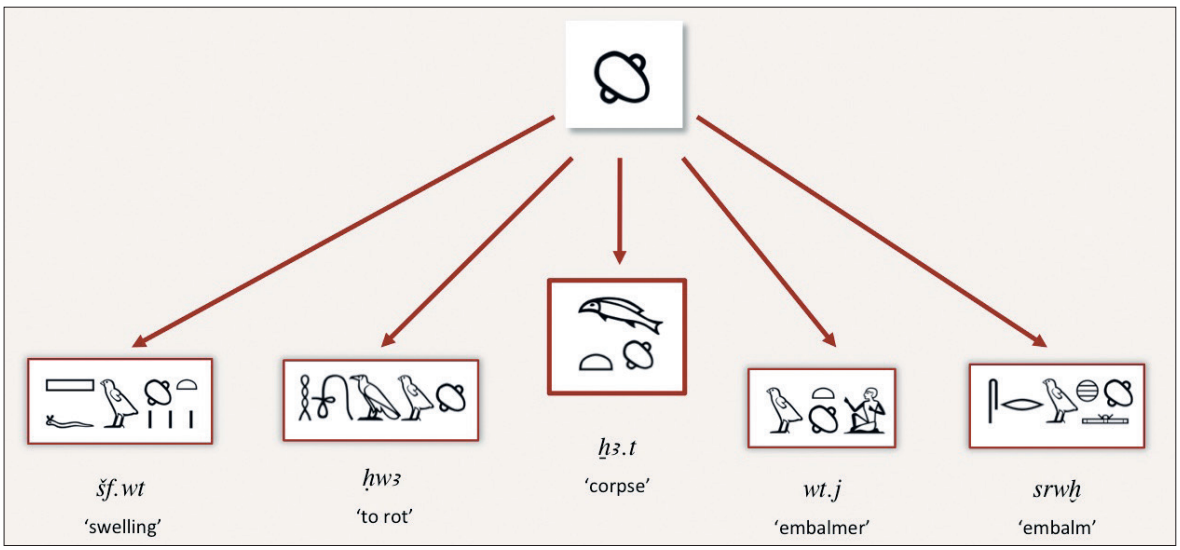


Fig. 1. Words classified by sign Aa2.

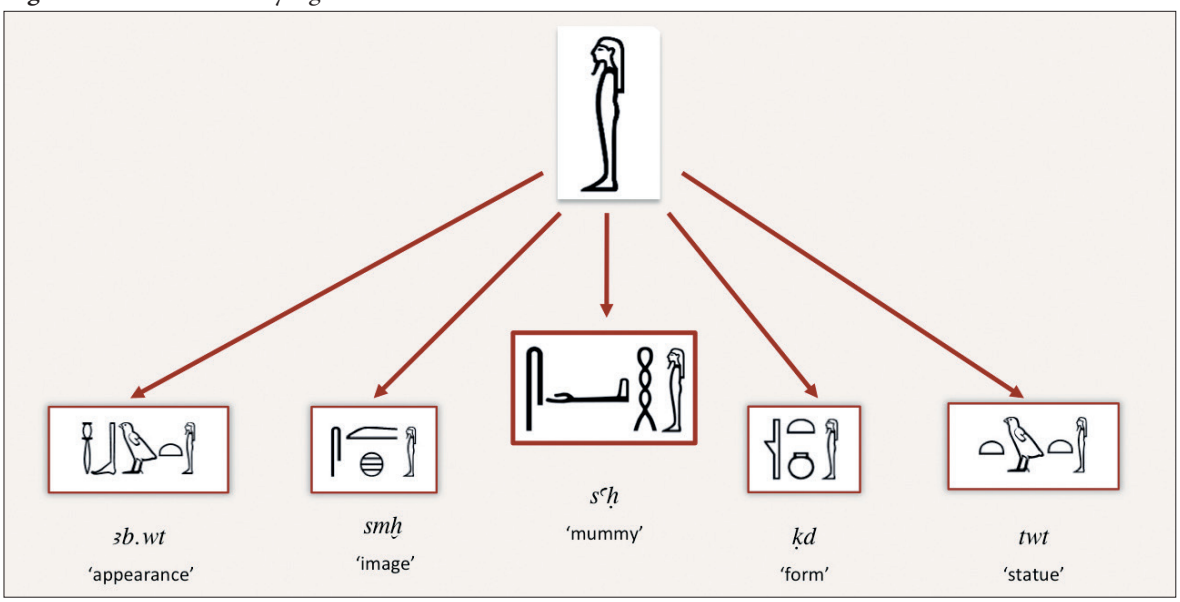


Fig. 2. Words classified by sign A53.

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Fig. 3. Scene from the Book of the Dead of Hunefer, New Kingdom, 19th Dynasty (after Taylor 2001, p. 190, fig. 133).

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